

THE ANTI-SLOP CHECKLIST

100 TELLS YOUR UI IS AI SLOP.

a tick-box list for the new way: you vibecode your interfaces now. here's how to ship something that doesn't look like everyone else's.

run every screen against this before it goes live. **own the look. don't average it.**

the new way is simple. you don't rent your interface anymore, you build it.
claude writes the screens, you direct them.

which is incredible.

it's also exactly where the trap is.

the model builds fast. it also builds the average.

ask an ai for a ui and it hands you the middle of everything it has ever seen. the safe gradient.
the default font. the same three feature cards. it looks finished. it just doesn't look like *you*.

1- but pedro... if the ai made it and it works, isn't that good enough ? no... working and not-slop
are two different things. a screen can pass and still feel like elevator music. technically fine.
instantly forgettable.

THE ANALOGY

slop is the lightweight umbrella made of newspaper. looks great in the shop, holds up in a
mockup. the second real rain hits, real users, real long text, real empty states, it folds.

how to use this

100 tells, sorted into 8 groups. open your screen next to it and tick every box that's true. each
tick is the model choosing for you instead of you choosing. a couple is normal. a column of
them means you shipped the default and called it a design.

PS. none of these are bugs. that's what makes them sneaky. every one looks fine on its own. you only catch
them by clicking through like a human, not by staring at one pretty frame.

THE 8 GROUPS

01	typography & text	10 tells
02	colors, shadows & gradients	14 tells
03	layout & sizing	14 tells
04	interaction & state logic	12 tells
05	ui elements & components	16 tells
06	content & strategy in the ui	13 tells
07	tokens & architecture	15 tells
08	ai evaluator hallucinations	6 tells

01 typography & text

10 TELLS

- ☐ **1. the inter font default**
every ai tool ships inter out of the box. if you didn't choose it, it chose you.

- ☐ **2. system sans-serif fallbacks**
a generic system fallback means nobody styled the type on purpose.

- ☐ **3. geist over-reliance**
geist shows up because the training data is full of it, not because it fits your brand.

- ☐ **4. space grotesk by default**
reaching for space grotesk to fake a "tech" feel with zero brand reason.

- ☐ **5. instrument serif interjections**
one random word in a sans headline swapped to a serif, copying a trend it doesn't understand.

- ☐ **6. all-caps eyebrow headings**
tiny, heavily tracked uppercase label sitting above every single header.

- ☐ **7. clunky serif body text**
heavy serifs for long copy to look "editorial". reads badly on screen.

- ☐ **8. ultra-thin serifs**
hairline serifs that look elegant in a mockup and vanish in real ui.

- ☐ **9. missing type hierarchy**
h1, h2 and body share one weight and barely change size. everything reads flat.

- ☐ **10. gradient heading text**
background-clip gradient on the hero h1 because the pattern shows up everywhere.

02 colors, shadows & gradients

14 TELLS

- ☐ **11. purple-to-blue gradient**
the "safe" saas gradient. the average of ten thousand landing pages.
- ☐ **12. purple on white**
bright purple over stark white as a default "high-tech" signal.
- ☐ **13. raw tailwind indigo**
indigo-600 straight from the utility class. no brand color in sight.
- ☐ **14. permanent dark theme**
defaulting to dark mode to feel premium and hide weak color choices.
- ☐ **15. unprompted neon glows**
neon accents injected into a neutral palette nobody asked for.
- ☐ **16. large ambient glows**
soft giant blurred circles behind random elements to fake depth.
- ☐ **17. colored box shadows**
saturated colored shadows under cards instead of natural neutral ones.
- ☐ **18. chaotic shadow recipes**
every modal, button and card on its own shadow value. no elevation system.
- ☐ **19. generic glassmorphism**
frosted-glass blur on everything, lifted from a 2022 trend window.
- ☐ **20. aurora / mesh backgrounds**
shifting mesh gradients used as a crutch when the copy and imagery are missing.
- ☐ **21. bright minimalist accents**
sterile black-and-white plus one aggressive accent when no style was specified.
- ☐ **22. poor color contrast**
light gray text on white that fails the most basic accessibility check.
- ☐ **23. saturated color tension**
clashing saturated colors in one viewport, killing the focal point.
- ☐ **24. accents drifting in**
a second accent sneaking into an iteration because the math didn't balance.

03 layout & sizing

14 TELLS

- ☐ **25. uniform 16px radius**
the same 16px curve on big containers, nested cards and tiny buttons alike.
- ☐ **26. uniform 24px padding**
24px wrapped around everything. no breathing room, no hierarchy.
- ☐ **27. centered hero, no asymmetry**
perfectly centered top section, no dynamic layout, no product shot.
- ☐ **28. three identical feature cards**
three columns, same weight, same padding, same height.
- ☐ **29. icon centered on the card**
a generic circular icon dropped top-center of every feature card.
- ☐ **30. colored left border on cards**
one of the most reliable tells there is. straight from a scraped library.
- ☐ **31. colored top border on cards**
the same artifact, rotated. still unstyled.
- ☐ **32. bento box for the sake of it**
unrelated features crammed into a tight grid because it's trendy.
- ☐ **33. horizontal "1, 2, 3" steps**
the same three-step "how it works", laid out sideways.
- ☐ **34. vertical "1, 2, 3" steps**
the exact same sequence, just stacked.
- ☐ **35. stat banner row**
a strip of impressive (often invented) metrics right under the hero.
- ☐ **36. pill badge above the h1**
a little "now in beta" badge floating above the headline.
- ☐ **37. drifting container margins**
outer margins jumping section to section. 1200 then 1440, no consistency.
- ☐ **38. desktop columns stacked for mobile**
"responsive" by stacking everything into one endless scroll.

04 interaction & state logic

12 TELLS

- ☐ **39. no hover states**
looks done standing still. does nothing when the mouse arrives.

- ☐ **40. no focus states**
no focus ring. keyboard users locked out.

- ☐ **41. no active states**
buttons that give no feedback when you press them.

- ☐ **42. no disabled states**
no visual cue for what you can't click yet.

- ☐ **43. no error states**
only the happy path designed. forms have no idea how to fail.

- ☐ **44. no empty states**
the dashboard with no data, no projects, nothing, never got designed.

- ☐ **45. no loading states**
no skeletons, no spinners. as if the network is always instant.

- ☐ **46. buttons snapping, no easing**
states flip instantly instead of a smooth transition.

- ☐ **47. generic scroll fade-ins**
the same opacity 0-to-1 fade on every element. a default, not motion design.

- ☐ **48. states bolted on late**
focus and error styles added at the end, clashing with the rest.

- ☐ **49. touch targets too small**
mobile elements that look nice and ignore the size of a finger.

- ☐ **50. ignores motion sensitivity**
animations that never check prefers-reduced-motion.

05 ui elements & components

16 TELLS

- ☐ **51. emoji chips**
unicode emojis stuffed in status chips to cover for no real icons.
- ☐ **52. emojis in the sidebar**
nav icons swapped for emojis. cheapens the whole thing.
- ☐ **53. the ai sparkle**
the four-point sparkle slapped on a button to call a plain feature "smart".
- ☐ **54. gradient initial avatars**
code-drawn gradient + initials standing in for real photos.
- ☐ **55. 3d floating blobs**
glossy abstract 3d shapes as hero art when there's no real screenshot.
- ☐ **56. plastic ai illustrations**
impossibly smooth, well-lit people staring at laptops. uncanny.
- ☐ **57. "trusted by" logo soup**
a row of generic or invented logos to fake credibility.
- ☐ **58. overdesigned fake dashboards**
charts everywhere that look finished and map to no real data.
- ☐ **59. borders around everything**
a 1px box around every block to force separation.
- ☐ **60. progress bars for nothing**
completion rings as filler with no real sequence behind them.
- ☐ **61. undifferentiated inputs**
fields with no visible active or valid state. forms fall apart.
- ☐ **62. delete styled like save**
"delete workspace" sitting next to "save" in the same color.
- ☐ **63. floating action button clutter**
corner bubbles overlapping the content you're trying to read.
- ☐ **64. duplicate components**
three versions of the same button because nothing remembers the master.
- ☐ **65. raw shadcn defaults**
the library's out-of-the-box look pasted in with zero customization.
- ☐ **66. can't draw a custom svg**
stuck on lucide because custom vector math is hard for the model.

06 content & strategy in the ui

13 TELLS

- ☐ **67. "build the future of..."**
a hero line averaged from every saas headline ever written.
- ☐ **68. "your all-in-one platform"**
a template phrase that explains nothing about the product.
- ☐ **69. "scale without limits"**
a promise that tells you nothing about how the thing actually works.
- ☐ **70. copy that fits but misses**
paragraphs that fill the box perfectly and miss the job the screen has to do.
- ☐ **71. signals with nothing behind them**
"new" tags and alert dots on things with no real notification.
- ☐ **72. flat visual hierarchy**
primary action, metadata and footer all shouting at the same volume.
- ☐ **73. the linkedin pattern**
avatars and profile settings given more weight than the actual task.
- ☐ **74. fake "modern" tone**
glossy tech polish slapped on a plumber, killing the trust it needed.
- ☐ **75. the shutterstock feeling**
finished but empty. the ui version of stock photography.
- ☐ **76. no semantic html**
styled divs everywhere. no nav, no main under the hood.
- ☐ **77. vibe-coded incoherence**
every screen fine alone, none of them feel like one mind built them.
- ☐ **78. happy-path only**
design treated as success states. edge cases never mapped.
- ☐ **79. elevator music aesthetics**
technically competent, totally forgettable. the average of every dashboard.

07 tokens & architecture

15 TELLS

- ☐ **80. unstable token baseline**
components that map to no shared token library.
- ☐ **81. hardcoded hex**
raw #8b5cf6 in the code instead of var(--primary).
- ☐ **82. hardcoded pixels**
a random 23px margin instead of a real 4 or 8pt scale.
- ☐ **83. more than 3 shadow recipes**
a fresh shadow invented for every new component.
- ☐ **84. flat elevation**
a dropdown, a modal and a flat card all the same distance off the page.
- ☐ **85. can't do page-level overrides**
ask for one denser page and it breaks the whole theme.
- ☐ **86. style fragmentation**
every new screen inventing its own local rules.
- ☐ **87. fails the 80% token test**
fewer than 80% of elements trace back to the system.
- ☐ **88. style applied without meaning**
"swiss" or "neo-brutalist" used as a skin, none of the reasoning.
- ☐ **89. designed for the framework**
built around what's easy to generate in react, not what's easy to use.
- ☐ **90. polish hiding missing rules**
beautiful in a mockup, breaks the second real long text shows up.
- ☐ **91. shifting component positions**
a button moving between iterations because it forgot the parent.
- ☐ **92. wireframe in disguise**
colors and clicks, still hollow and draft-like underneath.
- ☐ **93. dribbble convention bias**
copying whatever's trending instead of solving the actual problem.
- ☐ **94. no intent architecture**
buttons and menus generated with no constraints governing them.

08 ai evaluator hallucinations

6 TELLS

these aren't slop in the screen. they're slop in the tool you point at the screen. the ai grading your ux inventing problems that aren't there.

- ☐ **95. the seafood / sushi false alarm**
failing a restaurant for being labelled "seafood" when it clearly serves sushi.
- ☐ **96. friction flagged as a flaw**
calling out necessary ux friction, like hiding seating until a time is picked.
- ☐ **97. invented user clicks**
claiming the user picked the top tier when the log says mid-range.
- ☐ **98. fabricated timestamps**
making up when someone touched an element to force a failure story.
- ☐ **99. valid filters called useless**
failing a whole filter system over one missing niche tag.
- ☐ **100. ignores human logic**
missing the real-world physics and business reasons a screen is built the way it is.

THE TAKEAWAY

the model that builds your ui and the model that grades it are the same kind of machine. it averages. trust it for speed. don't trust it for taste. that part is still yours.

PS. i'm the lab rat on this one. half the boxes on this list, i've ticked on my own screens before catching them. that's the point. the list isn't to shame the ai. it's so you choose the parts that make it yours.